The Heritage Landmarks of Fort Canning

Dhoby Ghaut MRT Route (Exit B · Tree Tunnel) to Fort Canning MRT · Checkpoints numbered in walking order.

START FROM
Dhoby Ghaut MRT NS24 · NE6 · CC1

START FROM
Fort Canning MRT DT20



YOUR WALKING ROUTE

Dhoby Ghaut MRT to Fort Canning MRT

Exit B · enter via the Fort Canning Tree Tunnel

60-75 mins | ~1.8 km trail | Mostly downhill after Stop 2

1. **Battlebox** — World War II · 1936 - 1942
2. **Fort Gate** — Military Fort · 1859 - 1907
3. **Gothic Gate** — Old Christian Cemetery · 1822 - 1865
4. **Sang Nila Utama Garden** — Ancient Singapura · 14th Century
5. **Raffles Garden** — Government Hill · Early 1800s
6. **Fort Canning Green** — Post - Fort Transformation · 1920s
7. **Jubilee Park** — Jubilee Park · 1935 onwards

MULTIPLE ACCESS POINTS & TRANSIT HUBS

Dhoby Ghaut MRT (NS24 / NE6 / CC1)

Exit B leads directly to the Fort Canning Tree Tunnel & Canning Rise pedestrian underpass to enter the northern park slopes (Stop 1 on the Dhoby Ghaut MRT walking route).

Fort Canning MRT (DT20)

Exit B opens directly into Jubilee Park & the western foothills. Outdoor escalators connect uphill towards Sang Nila Utama Garden (Stop 1 on the Fort Canning MRT walking route).

VISITOR CHECKPOINTS & HERITAGE MILESTONES

1 World War II · 1936 - 1942
- Battlebox

2 Military Fort · 1859 - 1907
- Fort Wall
- Fort Gate
- Old Gunpowder Magazine
- Sally Port
- 9-Pound Cannon

3 Old Christian Cemetery · 1822 - 1865
- Cemetery Walls
- Gothic Gate
- Cupolas
- Napier Monument

4 Ancient Singapura · 14th Century
- Sang Nila Utama Garden
- Pancur Larangan
- Keramat Iskandar Shah

5 Government Hill · Early 1800s
- Raffles House
- Raffles Garden
- Flagstaff
- Lighthouse
- Timeball

6 Post - Fort Transformation · 1920s
- Reservoir

7 Jubilee Park · 1935 onwards
- Jubilee Park

Checkpoint 1:

World War II 1936 - 1942

Location: Cox Terrace, nine metres beneath Fort Canning Hill



Battlebox Entrance



Fortress Plotting Room in Battlebox



Signal Room in Battlebox

Malaya Command Underground

Between the late 1930s and early 1940s, the British built an underground command centre beneath Fort Canning Hill. Known today as the Battlebox, it served as headquarters for Malaya Command during the Malayan Campaign. Its protected rooms were design to support military planning during air raids and bombardment.

Historical Facts & Landmarks

On 15 February 1942, Lieutenant-General Arthur Percival and his senior commanders made the decision here to surrender Singapore to Japanese forces. The bunker therefore stands as one of the most significant World War II sites in Singapore.

Field Tip:
Look for the concealed hillside entrance and ventilation features, and book a guided tour to better understand the bunker's internal layout.

Checkpoint 2:

Military Fort 1859 - 1907

Location: Hilltop plateau surrounding Fort Canning Centre and Fort Gate



Sally Port



Fort Wall, Fort Gate



9-Pound Cannon

The Hilltop Fortress

In the late 1850s the British converted Government Hill into a fortified stronghold to defend Singapore. The new citadel was named Fort Canning after Charles John Canning, and its walls, gates and artillery were designed to command the harbour approaches. The fort remained in military use until it was decommissioned in 1907.

Historical Facts & Landmarks

The Fort Wall and Fort Gate are surviving features of the citadel.

The Old Gunpowder Magazine stored ammunition, while the Sally Port provided a controlled secondary exit.

The 9-Pound Cannon recalls the artillery once positioned on the hill.

Field Tip:
Inspect the thick masonry walls, the gate passage and the cannon platforms to imagine how the fortress once operated.

Checkpoint 3:

Old Christian Cemetery · 1822 - 1865

Location: Hilltop cemetery precinct near Fort Canning Green on Fort Canning Hill



Cemetery Walls



Napier Monument



Cupolas



Gothic Gate

A Cemetery on the Hill

Fort Canning once held Singapore's earliest Christian cemetery, used in the first decades of the colonial settlement. Important residents, soldiers and children were buried here between the 1820s and mid-19th century. Although most graves were later cleared, several architectural remnants survive.

Historical Facts & Landmarks

The Cemetery Wall defined the burial ground, while the Gothic Gate and Cupolas formed its distinctive entrance and structures.

The Napier Monument survives as one of the best-known memorials from the former cemetery, preserving the memory of an early colonial family.

Field Tip:
Look closely at the conserved brickwork and memorial elements to understand how the hill once served both the living settlement and its dead.

Checkpoint 4:

Ancient Singapura · 14th Century

Location: Southern slopes near Canning Rise & Cox Terrace, and the keramat precient on Fort Canning Hill



Sang Nila Utama Garden



Pancur Larangan



Keramat Iskandar Shah

Bukit Laragan & Royal Memory

Long before British arrival, Fort Canning Hill was known as Bukit Larangan, or 'Forbidden Hill'. Historical traditions and archaelogoical finds suggest that the hill was an important royal centre in 14th - century Singapura. Sang Nila Utama Garden re-imagines a Southeast Asian palace garden, while Pancur Larangan evokes the spring linked to royal bathing traditions. The nearby keramat is traditionally associated with Iskandar Shah, remembered as one of the last Malay rulers connected to Singapore.

Historical Facts & Landmarks

Sang Nila Utama Garden uses split brick gates, reflective pools and culturally significant plants to interpret palace-garden design.

Pancur Larangan refers to the 'Forbidden Spring' once associated with the royal court.

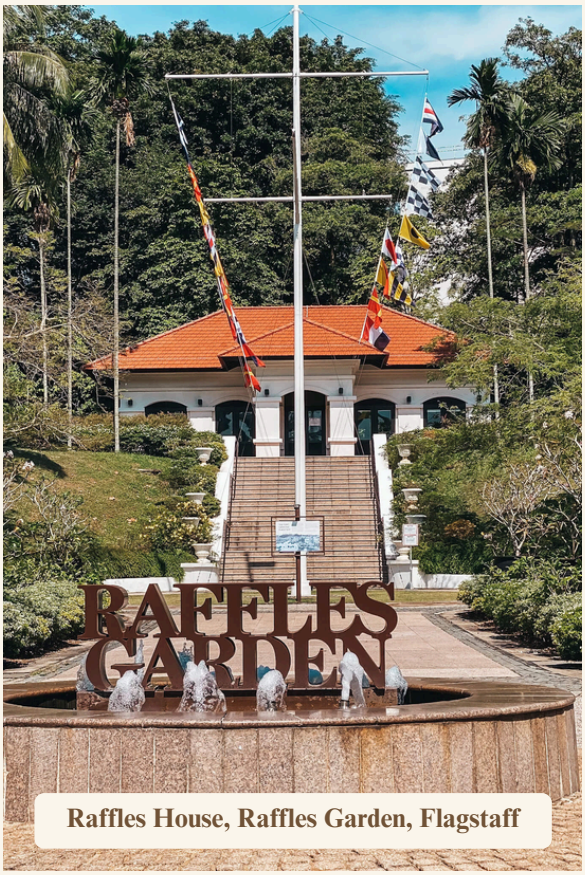
Keramat Iskandar Shah reflects the hill's enduring role in local memory and sacred geography,

Field Tip:
Walk through the candi bentar gateways, observe the reflective pools, and approach the keramat respectfully.

Checkpoint 5:

Government Hill Early 1800s

Location: Upper hill plateau near Fort Canning Centre, Raffles Garden and the Fort Canning Lighthouse



Raffles House, Raffles Garden, Flagstaff



Timeball



Lighthouse

Raffles, Residence & Reform

After 1819 the British claimed the hill and renamed it Government Hill. In 1823 Sir Stamford Raffles built his residence here, and the summit became the home of successive colonial governors. The area also developed as a centre of scientific interest, administration and communication.

Historical Facts & Landmarks

Raffles House marks the site of the early Government House.

Raffles Garden commemorates Raffles' interest in natural history and the first botanical experiments on the hill.

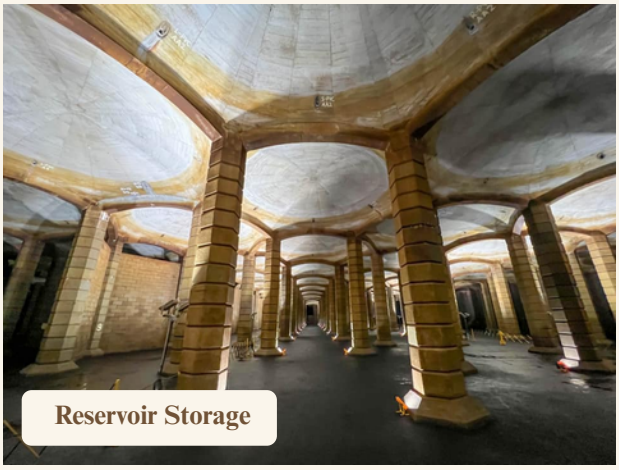
The Flagstaff, Lighthouse and Timeball formed part of a communication system that helped ships and signalled time across the harbour.

Field Tip:
Stand near the summit and imagine the open harbour view that once made this hill ideal for government and communication.

Checkpoint 6:

Post - Fort Transformation · 1920s

Location: Central hilltop reservoir precinct beneath Fort Canning Green



Reservoir Storage



Surface of Reservoir

From Fort to Reservoir

After the military fort lost its strategic value, much of the old citadel was dismantled in the 1920s. The hilltop was then adapted for civic infrastructure with the construction of the Fort Canning Service Reservoir. The change marks a new phase in which the hill shifted from defence to public utility.

Historical Facts & Landmarks

Completed in the late 1920s, the reservoir increased Singapore's water-storage capacity. Its construction altered the military landscape and explains why only parts of the former fort survive today.

The open green above it now hides an important layer of the hill's modern history.

Field Tip:
Pause at the open hilltop lawn and consider how essential infrastructure can reshape a historic site without fully erasing its past.

Checkpoint 7:

Jubilee Park 1935 onwards

Location: Western foothills near Fort Canning MRT and River Vallery Road



Slide at Jubilee Park



Pirate ship playground at Jubilee Park



Swing at Jubilee Park



Nature playground at Jubilee Park

Recreation on the Western Slope

Jubilee Park represents Fort Canning's recreational chapter. The area was once known as King George V Jubilee Park, named to mark the 1935 Silver Jubilee of King George V and Queen Mary. Over time, the western slope became a popular leisure zone associated with public recreation and family outings.

Historical Facts & Landmarks

The area later connected to attractions such as the River Valley Swimming Pool, Van Kleef Aquarium and National Theatre.

Today Jubilee Park has been reimagined as a welcoming public space that links the hill's heritage with everyday use.

Field Tip:
Use Jubilee Park as an accessible starting point, then move uphill to see how recreation and hertiage meet on the same landscape.